was a very diplomatic answer. The super sleuth of India was merely repeating from his letter marked ‘Secret’, dated 22 May 1991, to the Prime Minister. The world by then knew the identity of the ‘lady’ who had killed Rajiv Gandhi. But Narayanan chose to remain silent. His focus seemed to be on the filter coffee in front of him.

After a lot of coaxing, the bespectacled, soft-spoken sleuth told Anirudhya that certain parts of the video cassettes were ‘blurred’, echoing Kaarthikeyan’s earlier statement. But who would have blurred the contents? There was no reply. The coffee was over. But the seasoned spy in Narayanan could evade answering a critical question even when he had no coffee to use as an excuse. He looked straight into Anirudhya’s eyes and said, ‘You find out.’ Anirudhya was not willing to quit. He asked, ‘Do you think the cassettes were tampered with?’ Narayanan, a veteran at handling such questions, shot back, ‘Why don’t you find out? I will be happy to know your findings.’ But Anirudhya was not an investigator. He did not have the power to get hold of the tape. Narayanan then added, ‘Your stories on the assassination suggest you sometimes know more than the SIT. I would appreciate it if you enlightened us.’ Anirudhya understood that India’s intelligence head was upset with the questions and that he was in no mood to cooperate any further.

A section of the press was catering to the LTTE. In a damaging indictment, the SIT’s investigation had dug up how Sivarasan, who had masterminded the assassination, had, in fact, been ‘trained in handling sophisticated arms and ammunitions, explosives and telecommunication work and close combat warfare at a training camp in Kumbakonam in Tamil Nadu in 1983 by certain intelligence organizations’. Significantly, this was the first time a government agency was admitting the existence of training camps on its soil. The revelation also came in handy for those who sympathized with the Tamil Tigers.